

Bring Home The Movies

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The last time we reviewed projectors was in March last year. A lot has changed over the past 15 months or so. For one, LCD and Plasma TVs, which are the projectors' main competition, have gotten bigger, and cheaper. Projectors have also evolved, albeit at a slower rate. The whole move by nearly all projector manufacturers towards a more *jack-of-all-trades* approach—when it comes to performance—is a recently surfacing trend. We assume this is done to ensure easier market acceptance of their products—an important criteria for a product like a projector whose sales can hardly be compared to *hot cakes*.

Courtesy this all-rounder approach, nearly all our test candidates were able to do better in a wide variety of tests instead of just excelling in a couple of tests. Although certain audiences may complain, we feel more users may be attracted to these

devices that are better able to withstand the onslaught of large screen flat panels.

That being said, projectors don't really compete with flat panels across the board. There are certain circumstances where a projector will be more beneficial and vice versa.

A projector scores big when it comes to size of the image displayed, and if you need a huge display for presentations, movies, or any content that you wish to be viewed by a roomful of people, then congratulations—you're barking up the right tree. With an image size that can exceed 120 inches from a distance of around 20 feet we're not joking about the size part. Consider that most projectors in the range of Rs 60,000 can easily manage an image of this size and with acceptable clarity, and a projector in the price range of Rs 90,000 would give you an even better and more

Projectors are more affordable than ever before and offer unmatched value per inch of display size. Select one from the bunch we've tested...

cinematic HD movie and gaming experience at the same colossal screen size. A very good screen would set you back by another Rs 20,000. Now, blowing just over Rs 1 lakh may seem expensive right? It is—but not when you consider what you're getting in return. Consider that a good 42-inch LCD TV (one third the screen size) costs around Rs 1 lakh as well. A 55-inch plasma panel would cost well over a lakh. Anyone who has ever watched movies, presentations, or even played games on such a large screen area will tell you the *bigger the better*. So get rid of the notion that projectors are expensive.

Rs 50,000 To Rs 1 Lakh

A Cinematic Experience

NEC VT595

The smaller brother of the VT700 and a good looking projector sporting a curved body design and a glossy white finish that combine to get it looking as slick as it is classy. The remote control isn't as smart looking, but the keys impart good feedback. The VT595 has somewhat decent connectivity options with VGA, DVI, S-Video and Composite connectivity on the video front. USB and RJ45 connects have also been provided. It's obvious the VT595 is aimed at the household audience looking for a projector that's both feature-rich and performs decently. A price tag of Rs 54,000 isn't too steep for its audience either.

DisplayMate spoke volumes about its lacking contrast ratio. In the colour tests, we found no serious issues—but felt there was scope for improvement in the colour rendition and quality. Also, the clarity of this projector wasn't really as impressive as we'd initially expected.

It didn't do a lot in the text tests also, so its use in presentations should be very limited. In the movie tests however, we experienced a small turnaround. Game quality was also pretty good, but not what we'd clas-

sify as very good, so gamers looking for a projector should look elsewhere.

For its price, the NEC VT595 offers a good feature set, it's easy to use, and most of all performs above what is acceptable for a device of its price. If you're serious about movies and/or gaming, then you need to look elsewhere.

NEC VT800

The bigger brother to both, the VT595 and the VT700, the VT800 is both bigger and better looking than both its smaller siblings. It's got an even higher quality piano-white finish and the body shape is attractively versatile—equally suitable for living room and board room alike. It's rich in connectivity options with an HDMI port to go with the VGA, Composite, and S-Video connects. RJ45 and USB connects are also available. With such connectivity options, this projector will suit *both* corporate and home users. The settings are very transparent and the menu layout excellent. It's even got settings for adjusting the aspect ratio and the options are bountiful. Choose between 4:3, 5:4, 16:9, 16:10, a wide enough array of aspect ratios for almost every usage pattern.

Calibrating this projector was a snap courtesy the excellently laid out menu. It performed well in DisplayMate with very good contrast and colour. Text quality is sharp and precise. The display on-screen is very sharp. Our movie tests were a lot of fun and we actually ran some of our favourite clips a number of times—amazing contrast, very sharp and accurate colours, and great brightness levels.

The only thing even better than watching movies on the VT800 was playing games on it. And this we all did, for at least half an hour per person!—after which we had to get on with



the test. *Crysis* comes to life with some amazing brightness, clarity, contrast and detailing. The price, not withstanding, if you need a projector for gaming, buy this one—you won't regret a whit.

At Rs 92,000, it's a little expensive, but it's a brilliant multimedia projector that excels at text and presentations. Although corporates may not need such extensive performance across the board and they certainly won't like the price, this projector is a must have for serious movie and game junkies, and is a superb all-rounder.

NEC VT700

The smaller compatriot of the VT800 is a smaller clone to it in the looks department. It gives up an HDMI port for the more common DVI connect. Remember that HDMI is nothing but a newer standard for DVI video plus an audio

